Lesson 20: Enumerative Paragraphs 1: Focus, Topic Sentence, Supporting Ideas and Conclusion

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 2: Sentences and Paragraph Types · American History

Adapted from Building Academic Writing Skills by Lin Cui, Harper College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): Unit 4 Enumerative Paragraphs, sections I-V (Warm-up; Focus; Topic Sentence; Supporting Ideas; Conclusion in Enumerative Paragraphs).

In this lesson

You will study the enumerative paragraph, which explains one main idea with a short list of points (reasons, problems, ways or benefits): you will analyze two student paragraphs, write topic sentences, plan support in an outline and complete paragraphs with details and conclusions. This is the paragraph you will write most often in college, for example to explain "three causes of stress" in a psychology answer. Lesson 21 continues with more model paragraphs, transitions and the book's writing assignment.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain what an enumerative paragraph focuses on.
- Write topic sentences with a topic, a controlling idea and (optional) predictors.
- Plan supporting ideas and details in an outline, with the most important point last.
- Add explanations, examples and quotes to make support interesting.
- Write a conclusion that does not bring up a new topic.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
enumerative paragraph (e·NU·mer·a·tive)	a paragraph that explains a few points to support one main idea; to enumerate is to list or to count	"Public Laundromats in the U.S.A."
topic sentence	the sentence that shows the main idea; it usually comes at the beginning	There are three benefits to owning a dog.
controlling idea	the writer's opinion or feeling about the topic	Modern life creates a lot of anxieties in people, but there are **different ways to control stress**.
predictors (pre·DIC·tors)	(optional) the points you will explain in the body	I love my former boss for his **encouragement, fairness, and generosity**.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
typical (TYP·i·cal)	adjective: common, showing the nature of something	topics typical of enumerative paragraphs
controversial (con·tro·VER·sial)	adjective: causing argument because of different opinions	a controversial issue
barrier (BAR·ri·er)	noun: a challenge or difficulty that stops people from doing something	communication barriers among family members
flexibility, humility, generosity	nouns: being willing to change; being humble, not proud; being willing to give or share	understanding, flexibility, and humility
prospect (PROS·pect)	noun: something about the future	good economic prospects
imitate (IM·i·tate)	verb: follow or copy someone else's behavior	They are trying to imitate my husband and me.
relief (re·LIEF)	noun: the feeling when a worry disappears	Imagine my happiness and relief ...
infrequently (in·FRE·quent·ly)	adverb: not often	The buses run very infrequently.

Rules and explanations

What an enumerative paragraph does

- It focuses on **explaining some points to support a main idea**. It does not tell a story or argue for a controversial issue.
- It has a **title, a topic sentence, 2-4 supporting ideas with details** (explanations, examples, facts, quotes), **a conclusion and transitions** (words that connect ideas). Typical topics: characteristics of a good boss; benefits of owning a dog; advice to new international students.

The book's color code: title pink; topic sentence red; supporting sentences green; details blue; transitions yellow; concluding sentence(s) red. Without colored pens, write labels in the margin (TS, SS, D, TR, C).

The topic sentence (review of Unit 3)

- It shows the main idea and usually comes at the beginning (sometimes after background information).
- It has a **topic + a controlling idea + (optional) predictors**.
- It must be a complete sentence (subject + verb). It cannot be a question, an announcement ("I am going to write about ...") or a fact.
- Change the controlling idea and you get a different paragraph. Some topic sentences are more formal/academic, some more personal. The book's example for *Advice to new international students*:

- New international students will adapt to a new environment better if they prepare themselves well before leaving their native country.
- Finding a caring host family, working closely with professors and counsellors, and joining student clubs are the best ways for new international students to succeed.

Supporting ideas (review of Unit 3)

- Ask a question about the controlling idea; your answers are your supporting ideas.
- Make an outline (a plan of the paragraph). Delete irrelevant (not connected) and repetitive ideas.
- The "Hamburger Way": top bread = topic sentence; the middle = supporting sentences with details; the sauces = transitions; bottom bread = conclusion.
- Use facts, explanations, examples and quotes to make the paragraph interesting.
- The ideas follow a logical order: **the most important point is usually listed last.**

The book's example outline:

Parts	Outline ideas
Topic sentence	Three subjects often cause disagreement between teenagers and their parents.
Question	What are the three subjects?
Support 1 / Details	about friends / Teenagers: appearance, popularity; Parents: good students, good behavior
Support 2 / Details	about free time / Teenagers: games, movies, relaxing; Parents: reading, exercising, housework
Support 3 / Details	about school work / Teenagers: study not the only thing, favorite subjects; Parents: study, grades, college majors

You will read the finished paragraph, "To Communicate or Not to Communicate?", in Lesson 21.

The conclusion (review of Unit 3)

- It usually **restates** the main idea in different words or sentence structure, and usually **summarizes** the main points.
- It usually gives an **opinion**, a **prediction**, a **recommendation** or a **question**.
- It must **not** bring up a new topic.
- Example: "Stress has become an integral part of modern life. Isn't it time for each person to find a way to handle it?" (restatement + question)

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
>
> - A topic sentence needs a verb. Arabic needs no "be" in present-tense sentences, so check for is/are: not "A good boss very understanding" but "A good boss is very understanding."
> - Arabic writing often joins many ideas with "and" in one long sentence. Give each supporting idea its own sentence.

Practice

1. Warm-up: "Public Laundromats in the U.S.A." (Section I). Read the paragraph in your lesson material and color code it. Then answer:

- a) Which sentence is the topic sentence? What is the job of the first sentence?
- b) What are the three supporting sentences?
- c) Does the writer focus on telling a story, arguing for a controversial issue, or listing points to explain an idea?
- d) Does the paragraph have unity (is every sentence about the main idea)?
- e) What information is included in the conclusion?

2. Topic sentences (the table in Section III). Write the controlling idea and the predictors (if any). Is the sentence more formal/academic or more personal?

1. Three subjects often cause disagreement between teenagers and their parents.
2. I have learned to improve communication with my siblings in three areas: timing, topic, and tone.
3. A good boss usually displays the following characteristics: understanding, flexibility, and humility.
4. My neighbor's puppy Skippy has brought much joy to my family.

3. Book Exercise 1. Try different controlling ideas and write at least two different topic sentences for each topic.

1. Ways to improve grades in this writing class (your English writing course)
2. Advantages of technology for elderly people
3. Disadvantages of technology for young children
4. The best kitchen appliance for you
5. Your least favorite store

4. "The Joy of Having My Three Children" (Section IV). Read the paragraph in your lesson material.

- a) What is the topic sentence? What is the controlling idea?
- b) What are the three supporting ideas, and which words introduce each one?
- c) Find one explanation, one example and the quote.
- d) Which point is last, and why?
- e) Which conclusion types does the writer use (restatement, summary, opinion, prediction, recommendation, question)?

5. Book Exercise 2. Use two of your topic sentences from Practice 3 to make an outline for each, like the book's outline above. Check that the ideas support the topic sentence.

6. Book Exercise 3. Read "Ways to Reduce Stress" in your lesson material. Write 1-3 sentences of details for each place marked "(Add some details here ...)": a) physical exercise, b) talking to a friend or family member, c) doing chores.

7. Book Exercise 4. Read "Transportation in the Suburbs" in your lesson material. Write: a) a topic sentence, b) details about the problems when buses do not cover all areas, c) a conclusion.

Speak with your tutor

- "Here are my topic sentences from Practice 3: [paste]. For each one, tell me the topic, the controlling idea and the predictors. Is any of them a question, an announcement or a fact?"
- "Ask me 'What are the ...?' questions about my topic sentence, one at a time, so I can find three supporting ideas. Then help me order them, with the most important one last."
- "Here is my outline: [paste]. Find any irrelevant or repetitive ideas."
- "Here is my conclusion for 'Transportation in the Suburbs': [paste]. Which conclusion types did I use? Does it bring up a new topic?"

Writing task

Write a first enumerative paragraph from one of your outlines in Practice 5 (about 150-200 words): a short title; a topic sentence with a clear controlling idea; three supporting ideas, each with details (an explanation, an example, a fact or a quote); the most important point last; a conclusion. Use simple transitions such as First, Second and Finally (Lesson 21 teaches many more). Indent the first line.

Self-editing checklist:

- My topic sentence is a complete sentence with a topic and a controlling idea (not a question, an announcement or a fact).
- Each supporting idea answers the question I asked about my controlling idea, and each has at least one detail.
- My most important point is last.
- I deleted irrelevant and repetitive sentences.
- My conclusion restates the main idea in new words and adds an opinion, a prediction, a recommendation or a question, with no new topic.
- Every sentence has a subject and a verb.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

1. a) Topic sentence: "Most people living in the apartments do not have their own washer and dryer, but I think this situation creates some problems for them." The first sentence ("When I moved to Chicago ...") gives background information. b) "The transportation of dirty linen and clothes is the first problem." / "The second problem is having the exact change." / "The biggest problem of using public laundromats is hygiene." c) Listing points (three problems): it is enumerative. The short story about the neighbor's laundry is only a detail. d) Yes: every sentence is about problems with public laundromats. e) The concluding sentences, "Of course, for eight months in America, ... Imagine my happiness and relief when I finally bought my own first washing machine!" (book, Section V), express the writer's feeling (an opinion). They do not summarize the three problems. (c-e: example answers)

2. Your wording can be a little different.

1. Controlling idea: often cause disagreement; no predictors; formal/academic.
2. Controlling idea: I have learned to improve communication in three areas; predictors: timing, topic, tone; personal.
3. Controlling idea: displays the following characteristics; predictors: understanding, flexibility, humility; formal/academic.
4. Controlling idea: has brought much joy to my family; no predictors; personal.

The formal sentences are general and have no "I" or "my".

3. (example answers)

1. Students can improve their grades in this writing class by reading model paragraphs, following the writing process, and asking for feedback. / I have raised my writing grades by planning before I write and rewriting after feedback.
2. Technology helps elderly people stay healthy, safe, and connected with their families. / Video calls have made my grandmother's life much happier.
3. Too much screen time can harm young children's sleep, eyesight, and social skills. / My nephew's tablet has changed his behavior in worrying ways.
4. A microwave is the most useful kitchen appliance for a busy student because it saves time and effort. / My rice cooker is my best friend in the kitchen.
5. I avoid my local supermarket because of its long lines, high prices, and unfriendly staff. / Shopping at the electronics store downtown is always frustrating.

4. a) "It is a blessing that I have three children, aged 15, 11, and 6." Controlling idea: a blessing. b) Introduced by "First,", "However," and "The part I love the most is that": "First, they are not lonely anymore." / "However, with three children, I feel really old sometimes, but they make me feel young." / "The part I love the most is that they help me become a better person." c) Explanation: "When I had two children, they complained to me many times." Example: "Last month, when my second child participated in a cross-country competition ..., I ran next to her and cheered her on." Quote: "Children are mirrors of their parents." d) "They help me become a better person" is last because it is the most

important point ("The part I love the most"). e) Opinion and restatement: "My children are the joy of my life" restates "a blessing" in different words. (e: example answer)

5. (example answer) Topic sentence: Technology helps elderly people stay healthy, safe, and connected with their families. Question: How does technology help elderly people? Support 1: health; details: medicine reminders on the phone, online appointments with doctors. Support 2: safety; details: emergency buttons, doorbell cameras. Support 3 (most important): family; details: video calls with grandchildren, family photo groups.

6. (example answers) a) A run, a swim or even a 20-minute walk takes people's minds off their problems. After exercise, the body is tired in a good way, so it is easier to sleep. b) When people talk about a problem, they often understand it better, and a friend may suggest a solution. Even if the friend cannot help, the speaker feels less alone. c) Washing dishes or folding clothes is simple, repeated work, so the mind can rest. A clean home also helps people feel more in control of their lives.

7. (example answers) a) Public transportation in the suburbs causes many problems for people without a car. b) Some neighborhoods are more than a mile from the nearest bus stop, so people have to walk a long way or ask friends for a ride. Without a car, they cannot easily get to work, the supermarket or the doctor. c) Infrequent buses, long waits in the cold and areas with no service make suburban life hard for people without a car. Local governments should add more buses and routes. (summary + recommendation)

My notes